

London or Mumbai. Pakistan is becoming vulnerable to terrorist attacks, and we'd like to cooperate with it in whatever manner we can. It is cooperation of a general nature. The overall interest of both countries to fight terror should be the common objective." This significant statement may reduce tensions between the two neighbours that escalated after the 26/11 Mumbai attacks but it also means no more excuses for Zardari and Co.

All this comes with a rider, however, and a clear message that New Delhi has been disappointed with Pakistan's conduct. India has made it clear that Islamabad has to fulfill a set of prerequisites before the composite dialogue process can begin. "We are disappointed. We expected Pakistan to take more strident steps to tackle the perpetrators of terror on its soil," he added. Even though Pakistan has been trying hard to get India to restart the negotiations, the Indian foreign minister has made it clear to the Zardari Government that the country will only begin talking to Pakistan after some credible action against terror infrastructure is taken.

Quizzed on specifics, the minister was curt, "The Pakistan government

understands what that credible action is. Pakistan should take an unequivocal stand against terrorism. We have given them evidence about the training camps and infrastructure to be dismantled. These are some of the prerequisites for the dialogue to begin," he said. And now the ball is in Pakistan's court. "Let us wait for the reaction of the Pakistani government. Now that a new government has taken

A fresh proposal to Pakistan is India's deft move to deflect the increasing pressure on beginning a dialogue with its neighbour.

office in India, we are making this offer to them that we would like to be friends with them and that we want a stable Pakistan. Our neighbour should reciprocate." But there are enough warnings. On the 26/11 attacks too, New Delhi insists that its patience is running out, "Pakistan has to expedite the Mumbai investiga-

tions," he insists. The temperature is also rising on the issue of the neighbour's nukes falling in the hands of terrorists. "In a country where there is an element of instability, naturally these concerns come to the fore since Pakistan is a nuclear power."

India has made a proposal to Pakistan but behind this fresh proposal lies a pressure-deflecting tactic. While the country wants Islamabad to take visible steps on dismantling terror infrastructure, it has also demonstrated to its Western interlocutors that India is not being inflexible as it has made a new offer to Pakistan. This is a deft move by New Delhi as in the coming days, the pressure to begin a dialogue process with Pakistan is only going to mount. US President Barack Obama has already communicated this to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, and the message may only be reinforced when Singh meets Obama in July on the sidelines of the G-8 summit in Italy. In the coming days, as US Secretary of State Hilary Clinton jets into Delhi, worried that America's Af-Pak policy may be hit by growing Indo-Pak tensions, India's insistence on a new zero-tolerance policy on terror may prove an effective counter. ■

External Affairs Minister against terror'

and we would like to cooperate with it in whatever manner we can.

Q. Are you disappointed by its response to India's concerns?

A. We are disappointed. We expected Pakistan to take strident steps to tackle the perpetrators of terrorism on its soil but that hasn't happened.

Q. But what are the specific steps that Pakistan should undertake?

A. They will have to take credible action. I am sure its government understands what that credible action is. All we want is that Pakistan should take an unequivocal stand against terror that it will not allow any terror-

ist organisation to train on its soil. These are some prerequisites for the dialogue to begin.

Q. There are concerns there that the Obama Administration has put some curbs on outsourcing. Will you take it up when US Secretary of State Hilary Clinton visits India?

A. Outsourcing has always been a problem in the US. President Obama, in one of his recent interactions, mentioned Bangalore and Buffalo. The US should keep in mind that the benefits that flow out into it are because of outsourcing.

Q. You want to repair ties with neighbours. Is there a Krishna doctrine for the neighbourhood?

A. The Krishna doctrine is to strengthen our relationship with our immediate neighbours which will

be our priority and I hope our neighbours will reciprocate. This can be done through people-to-people contacts, through exchange of visits in the field of arts, music and science.

Q. In Sri Lanka, there's a growing concern on the plight of the Tamil civilians. What should the Rajapakse Government do?

A. Certain promises to the minority Tamils have not been implemented. The devolution of powers has not happened. The Sri Lankan Government should bring about a greater integration and harmony among different linguistic groups. The displaced Tamils must be rehabilitated.

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